



Paracas textile

The Paracas people of Peru made beautiful textiles. Many feature a godlike creature known as the “oculate being,” depicted here wearing a gold diadem and holding a snake.

Advanced American societies in this era had much in common: quarrying stone, creating beautiful artifacts, and worshipping multiple gods usually linked to nature (for example, the jaguar, the sun, and the moon). South American cultures were more advanced in their use of metals, but it was a Mesoamerican culture—the Maya—that left the most powerful and enigmatic monuments.

The Maya

The “Classic” period of Maya culture is normally dated from c. 300 to 900 CE. It flourished over a wide swath of Central America, especially the Yucatán and Guatemala’s steamy lowlands. At its heart stood a large number of important cities. Originally ritual centers, many grew into populous city-states.

The Maya built huge, often pyramidal stone temples, such as those at Tikal in Guatemala, and showed a great talent

plotting the positions of the sun and moon and predicting solar eclipses. Their calendar had two main cycles: a 260-day sacred year (13 cycles of 20 days) and a 365-day solar year (18 months of 20 days each, plus an “unlucky” 5-day period, which the Maya spent appeasing the gods).

Monte Albán and Teotihuacán

While Maya civilization was thriving, the Zapotec people of southern Mexico were creating their major center at Monte Albán (see BEFORE). The ruins of the city’s sacred and political center, dating mainly from c. 300 CE onward, show that this was another highly sophisticated society. A great central plaza is surrounded by monumental platforms, pyramids, staircases, and terraces. Other buildings include a ball court and an observatory. The architecture at Monte Albán shows influences from another significant

HOW WE KNOW

CELESTIAL CITIES

Mesoamericans often built their cities on precise, ritually significant grid patterns. At Teotihuacán, for example, the city’s grid lines up exactly 15.5° east of north, with the “Street of the Dead” (below) forming the main axis between the Pyramid of the Sun and the Pyramid of the Moon. Possibly this was intended to map out the heavens.



Early American Civilizations

Various advanced cultures flourished simultaneously in the Americas between the 1st century BCE and c. 400–600 CE—a period that includes part of the great Mesoamerican “Classic” eras. Perhaps the best known of these cultures was that of the Maya people, who with their stunning temples and scientific knowledge created one of the most extraordinary early American civilizations.

BEFORE

The advanced societies of Meso- and South America in the 1st centuries CE built on the legacy of earlier cultures, the Olmecs in Mexico, and the Chavín in Peru.

OLMECS AND ZAPOTEC

Maya writing, their calendar, and understanding of astronomy all owe a debt to the **Olmec culture** << 74–75 that flourished c. 1200–400 BCE near the coast of the Gulf of Mexico. The **Zapotec** city of Monte Albán in the valley of Oaxaca, which first appeared at the time of the later Olmecs, remained an important center until c. 600 CE.



BALL COURT AT MONTE ALBÁN

CHAVÍN CULTURE

Chavín culture << 74–75, widely diffused across Peru c. 1000–200 BCE, gave way to smaller coastal societies such as the Moche and the Nazca.

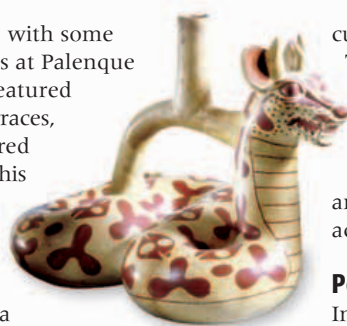
for carved stone reliefs, with some especially fine examples at Palenque in Mexico. Cities also featured palaces, open plazas, terraces, and courts where a sacred ball game was played. This seems to have been a strenuous affair in which the participants used their heads, hips, and shoulders to direct a rubber ball at its target.

Religious ritual played a major part in Maya life. They practiced forms of “auto-sacrifice” (self-mutilation involving the piercing of body parts), but more extreme scenarios involving torture and human sacrifice seem to be highly inaccurate and sensationalized.

Writing and the calendar

While the Olmecs developed a form of writing, some consider that the Maya should be credited with the first “real” Mesoamerican writing because theirs was more closely connected with actual speech. Their system comprised at least 800 glyphs (symbols).

The Maya also had a sophisticated calendar—probably using earlier Olmec concepts. This incorporated advanced astronomical knowledge that included



Moche stirrup-spouted jar

The Moche often combined different animals in their artifacts—this jar has the head of a deer, feline fangs, and a snake’s body.

cultural center, that at Teotihuacán (see right), a huge city northeast of present-day Mexico City that flourished c. 300–600 CE and had cultural links across Mesoamerica.

Peruvian societies

In South America, various Peruvian cultures flourished up to about 400–600 CE. The people of southern Peru’s Paracas peninsula were a mainly agricultural people, but were also extraordinarily talented weavers and embroiderers. Their art is preserved in the beautiful cloaks that the Paracas wrapped around mummified bodies.

The Nazca people lived on Peru’s southern coast, with an important center at Cahuachi in the Nazca Valley. They created irrigation systems to support intensive grain production, as well as puzzling “lines” in the desert that remain a mystery today.

On Peru’s northern coast, the Moche built a great administrative and religious complex at Sipán. Formidable warriors and inventive artists, they also created advanced valley irrigation techniques.

AFTER

Meso- and South America continued to give rise to a variety of new cultures, while Maya civilization underwent a major shift.

SOUTH AMERICA

From around 600 CE, the **Tiahuanaco** and **Huari** cultures emerged in the highlands of Bolivia and Peru, respectively. The **Chimú** of coastal Peru created a large state that fell to the **Incas 212–13** >> in the 15th century.

THE LATE MAYA PERIOD

From the 9th century CE, a number of southern Maya centers were abandoned—due to a range of factors, including **depleted resources** resulting from **intense cultivation**—while northern ones such as **Chichén Itzá 210–13** >> were still thriving and expanding. The Maya culture lived on, and today there are around 6 million Maya in Mexico, Guatemala, and Belize.



TIAHUANACO GOD

Maya ritual

This carving shows a bloodletting “auto-sacrifice.” Lady K’ab’al Xook pulls a thorny rope through her tongue as her husband, the king of Yaxchilán, holds a torch over her.